Banner Number 18: Tatum's Immaculate Double-Double Finishes Celtics Dominant Title Run

Boston dominates Dallas early, survives a shaky third quarter, and closes out a 106-88 Game 5 to clinch a record 18th NBA championship

By Joseph Tarlin, Boston Herald

Jayson Tatum and the Boston Celtics closed out the Dallas Mavericks 106-88 in Game 5 of the NBA Finals inside of an electric TD Garden in Boston, Massachusetts on Monday night, June 17, 2024. The Celtics only needed five games to get the job done and they did exactly that with consistent play all series to ultimately clinch the series 4-1 and deliver the franchise's record 18th championship. In a sold-out crowd of over 19,000 people, the Celtics jumped on Dallas early, survived a late push from Luka Doncic, and sent the Mavericks home while riding on a monster all-around Jayson Tatum performance.

Boston never trailed for a single second and took a commanding 28-18 lead after the first quarter. They extended the lead even further in the second quarter, turning a 10-point edge into a 67-46 halftime lead. Payton Pritchard's 49-foot half-court shot at the end of the second quarter had the building rocking during the intermission. Al Horford was a quiet catalyst in this stretch, hitting 3 of his 6 three-pointers and grabbing 9 rebounds, while Derrick White splashed four threes for a total of 14 points. The Celtics cushion widened to 26 points at one point in the third quarter, with Jayson Tatum in the middle of all of the action. Tatum finished with 31 points, 11 assists, and 8 rebounds, becoming just the sixth player in NBA history to have 30 points and 10 assists in a Finals-clinching game. "I wasn't thinking about going down in the history books out there, I was just trying to make the right read for my teammates every time I walked down the court," Tatum mentions. Jaylen Brown had to battle through a tough shooting night, going just 7 for 23 from the field. Brown was able finish with 21 points, 8 rebounds, and 6 assists, all done on 1 turnover the entire game. He mentions how "shots weren't falling for me early so I just tried to perform my duty on the defensive end and let JT cook. Winning a title, nobody remembers your shooting split, they remember the banner."

The Mavericks were fiercely competing all game and did not fold despite multiple Celtics efforts to run away with the game and series. Luka Doncic had a fantastic performance, finishing with 28 points, 12 rebounds, and 5 assists for a double-double. Dallas actually won the second half on the scoreboard 42-39, which trimmed the lead down to a margin of 18 for the final score of the game. Doncic mentions "we kept fighting, the boys were working and I could see they wanted it, but every time we made a push, they had an answer." Doncic, sitting slumped at his locker with a towel around his neck, also adds in "this is a great team over here, and it's not the last time we will be in the Finals, I can promise that." Kyrie Irving scored 15 points, while shooting inefficiently on a 5-16 night, while reserve Josh Green was a matchup nightmare, hitting 4 of his 6 three points for 14 points in only 22 minutes played. In an attempt at his second NBA title, Kyrie mentions "this one is going to sting for a while, but that's the nature of basketball in the NBA, and I can guarantee we will be back in a similar situation very soon." The Celtics shot a nearly identical 42.7 percent from the field compared to Dallas's 44.9 percent but also made 17 of 20 free throws for 85 percent while the Mavericks had a rough 7 of 13 night for 53.8 percent from the charity stripe. Boston also committed only 9 turnovers whereas Dallas had 13, and the Celtics turned these Mavericks mistakes into 17 points while only giving up 6 points off its own giveaways. This is an 11-

point swing that never showed up in the box score but decided plenty of possessions in this game. The Celtics also outrebounded Dallas offensively 15-7, and they out-ran Dallas on the fast break 16-9. Both teams fired from deep range at almost the same percentage, with Boston taking 39 threes at a 33.3% rate and Dallas taking 37 threes at a 29.7% rate.

Both coaches saw the same game from opposite sides of the floor. Celtics coach Joe Mazulla mentions how “our habits carried us tonight since we talked all series about staying organized and how to not get rattled, even when we knew they were going to make runs.” With the trophy being wheeled towards to podium right behind him, Mazzulla also mentions “this is for everybody in this organization who has believed in us the entire time, even when we traded away the talent that brought Boston the 2008 ring, this is all what is was for.” Jason Kidd was incredibly humble and gracious in his defeat, highlighting how “we fought, our guys never stopped competing, but they are the better team, simple as that.” As the horn sounded right around 11:00 pm, green and white confetti rained down onto the Celtics court. The team finished the postseason 16-3, a whopping 84.21% that is top 5 of all time in single season NBA postseason team win percentage. This was Boston’s first title since June 17, 2008, which made it exactly 16 years to this date, and the arena was chanting “18! 18! 18!.” Tatum climbed onto the scorer’s table with the Bill Russell trophy in his arms and excitedly screamed “this is for everybody who has ever put on this jersey, we just wanted to bring it home,” as his voice cracked over the noise. What a time it is to be alive in the city of Boston during this incredible 2024 NBA playoff run for the Celtics.

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